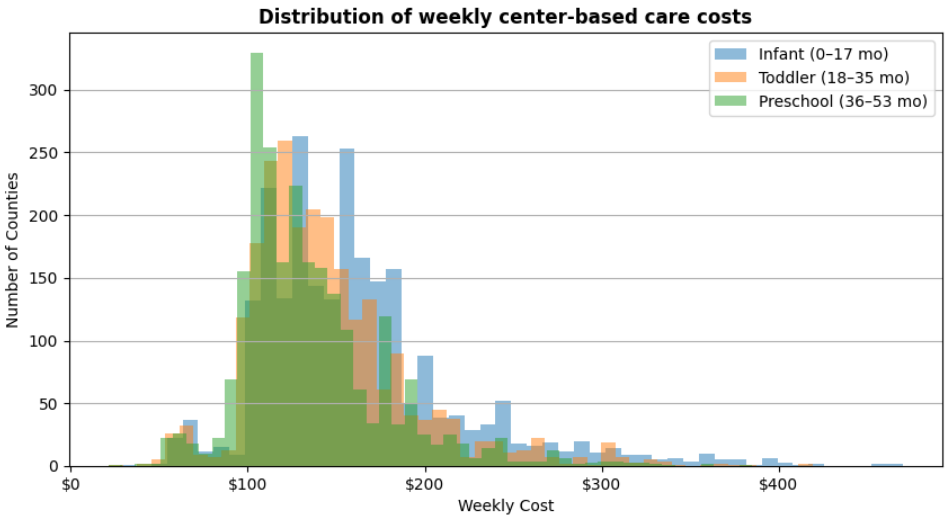
The Hidden Tax on Working Families: What Childcare Really Costs



Most US counties report weekly infant care costs between $100 - $175, reflecting the modal experience for most working families.

Infant costs (blue) are right-shifted relative to toddler and preschool, confirming that younger children cost more in nearly every market.

The long right tail extends beyond $400/week - driven by high-cost urban metros like New York City, San Francisco, and Boston.

Employers should offer childcare subsidies as a workforce benefit.

Legislators should expand subsidy eligibility.

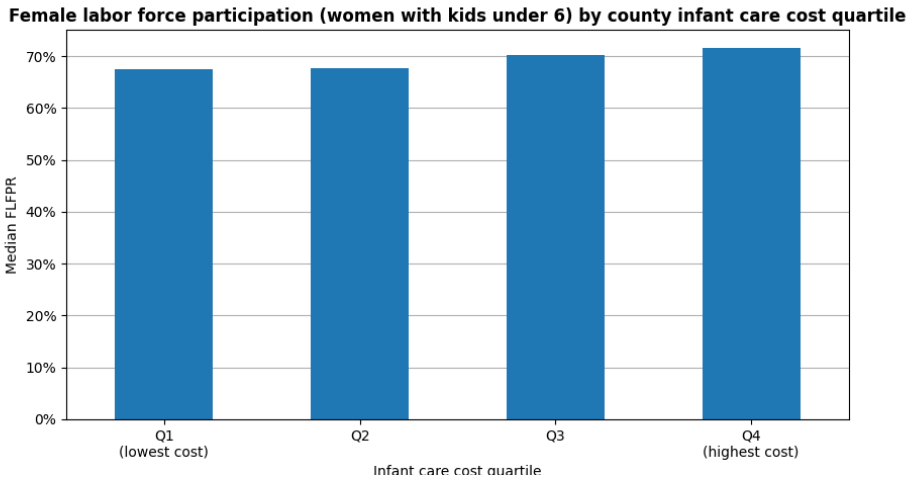
Researchers should use NDCP data to target the most burdened counties.

The majority of US counties report:

Median FLFPR rises slightly from Q1 (67%) to Q4 (72%), the highest cost counties have marginally higher female workforce participation

High-cost counties are predominantly urban with higher wages. Women in these areas can afford care and earn enough to make working worthwhile.

The burden falls hardest on moderate-income families caught between high costs and insufficient earnings.



Source: U.S. Dept. of Labor Women's Bureau - National Database of Childcare Prices (2008–2018)